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PREFACE AND ACKNOWLEDGMENTS



This book is the synthesis of, on one hand, the no-nonsense mathematical trader (self-styled “practitioner of uncertainty”) who spent his life trying to resist being fooled by randomness and trick the emotions associated with uncertainty and, on the other, the aesthetically obsessed, literature-loving human being willing to be fooled by any form of nonsense that is polished, refined, original, and tasteful. I am not capable of avoiding being the fool of randomness; what I can do is confine it to where it brings some aesthetic gratification.

Much has been written about our biases (acquired or genetic) in dealing with randomness over the past decade. My rules while writing this book have been to avoid discussing (a) anything that I did not either personally witness on the topic or develop independently, and (b) anything that I have not distilled well enough to be able to write on the subject with the slightest effort. Everything that remotely felt like work was out. I had to purge the text from passages that seemed to come from a visit to the library, including the scientific name dropping. I tried to use no quote that does not naturally spring from my memory and does not come from a writer whom I have intimately frequented over the years (I detest the practice of random use of borrowed wisdom – much on that, later). *Aut tace aut loquere meliora silencio* (only when the words outperform silence).